Mirza escaped death by a whisker when Taliban fighters were secretly allowed to march inside Mazar-e-Sharif on 25 May 1997. Although Pahlawan realised that he had made a mistake and ordered the execution of the Taliban fighters, it was too late for Mirza and his favourite city.

The Indian spy agency, which had recruited Mirza sometime in 1979 when he was just a middle rank army officer, was shocked by the development. An Indian spy codenamed S. Reddy, travelling to Prague around the time of Mirza's escape, was asked to establish contact. Assets were activated in Turkey to learn his whereabouts. A search within the community of Afghan migrants drew a complete blank. A few days later, Reddy heard that Mirza was staying at a five star hotel in Istanbul under a cover name. Ashfaq Khan, a seasoned operative in Frankfurt, was told to find him.

Within hours, Khan was in Istanbul looking for the Uzbek warlord who had commanded a force of fifty thousand fighters and ruled a free territory in northern Afghanistan before Pahlawan's treachery destroyed his fortunes.

Ashfaq had earlier met Mirza in Afghanistan in 1996 after the fall of Kabul to the Taliban but the meeting had lasted for just about five minutes. His task then had been to deliver aid to Mirza. Once again, he was assigned to help Mirza as much as he could. The hour-long meeting between the spy and the warlord focused on the emergence of the Taliban and Pakistan's tacit support to them which threatened India's interests.

'You cannot trust anybody in Afghanistan,' Reddy told me. 'Nothing is hidden from the warlords. R&AW made two effective recruitments during the Soviet invasion, each in a different camp. While Mirza fought against the mujahideen,